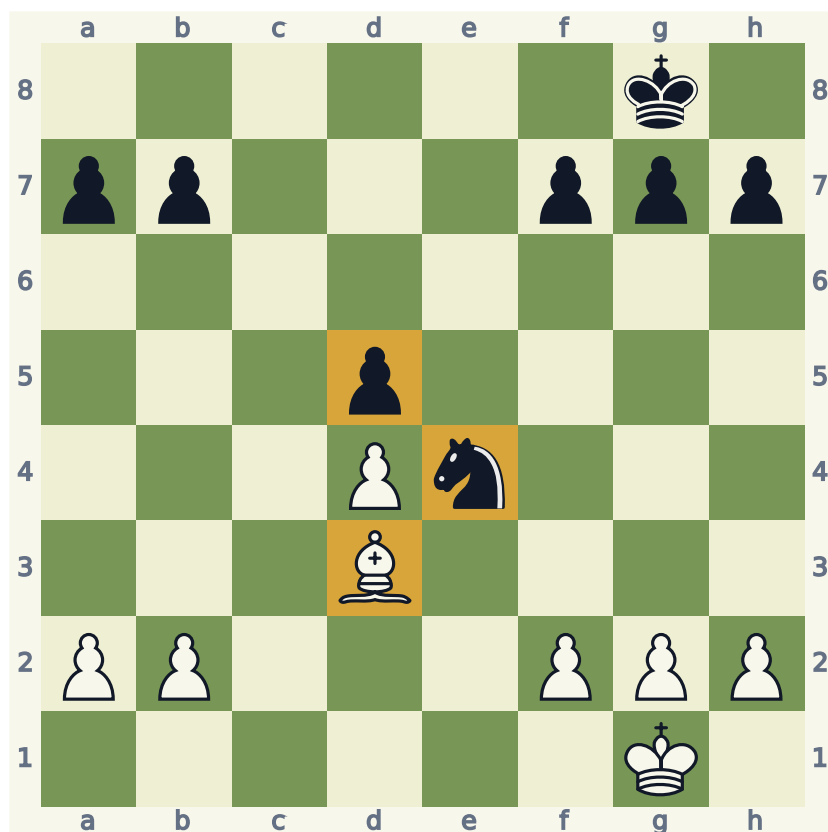


Purposeful exchanges

Judge what remains after the trade.

An exchange is good when the remaining position suits you better. It can remove a key defender, reduce an attack, expose a pawn weakness or lead to a favorable ending. Before trading, mentally remove the pieces and place the recapturing piece on its new square. Then evaluate again.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Ne4 is an active knight supported by d5.
- Bd3 can exchange it, but the recapture changes the pawn structure.
- After the trade, king activity replaces minor-piece activity as the main concern.

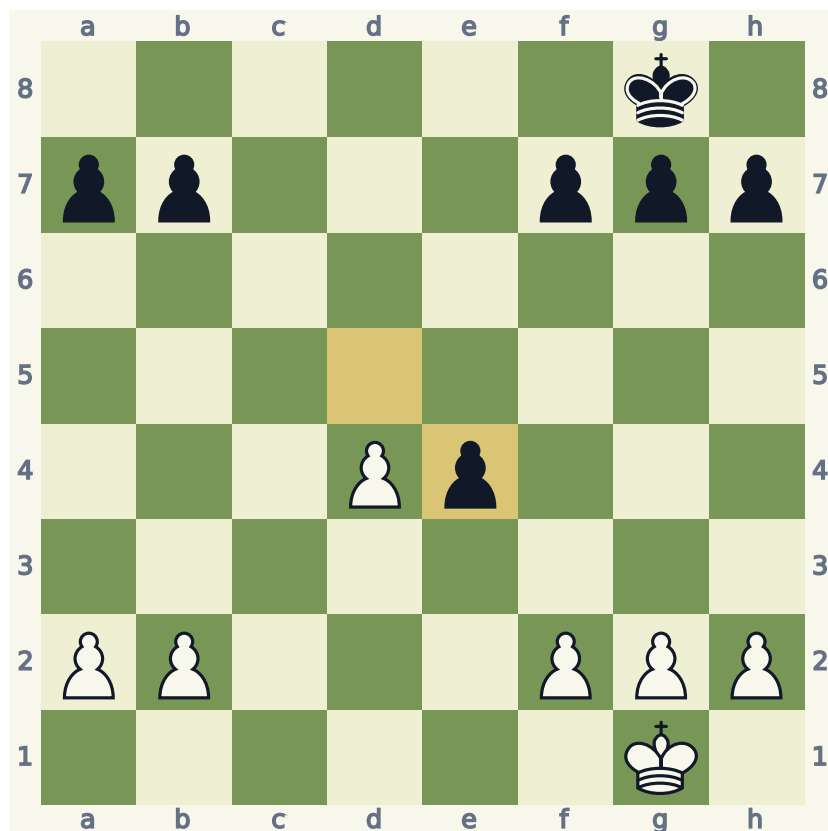
REMEMBER

- Name the concrete purpose of a trade.
- Put the recapturing pawn or piece on the board mentally.
- Inspect the resulting ending before exchanging.

Follow the logic

1. Bxe4 dxe4

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Bxe4

Remove the active knight. The decision also gives up a bishop, so judge the resulting position rather than celebrate the removal alone.

...dxe4

Black's d-pawn becomes an e4-pawn. It gains space but loses pawn support in this version.

Next decision

Both sides now need active kings. White's d4-pawn is passed, but its king is far away; Black can seek central access and pressure against the kingside.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black may welcome the exchange if the king can become active or if e4 restricts White effectively. White should compare keeping the bishop with entering the pawn ending, including the time needed to support d4.

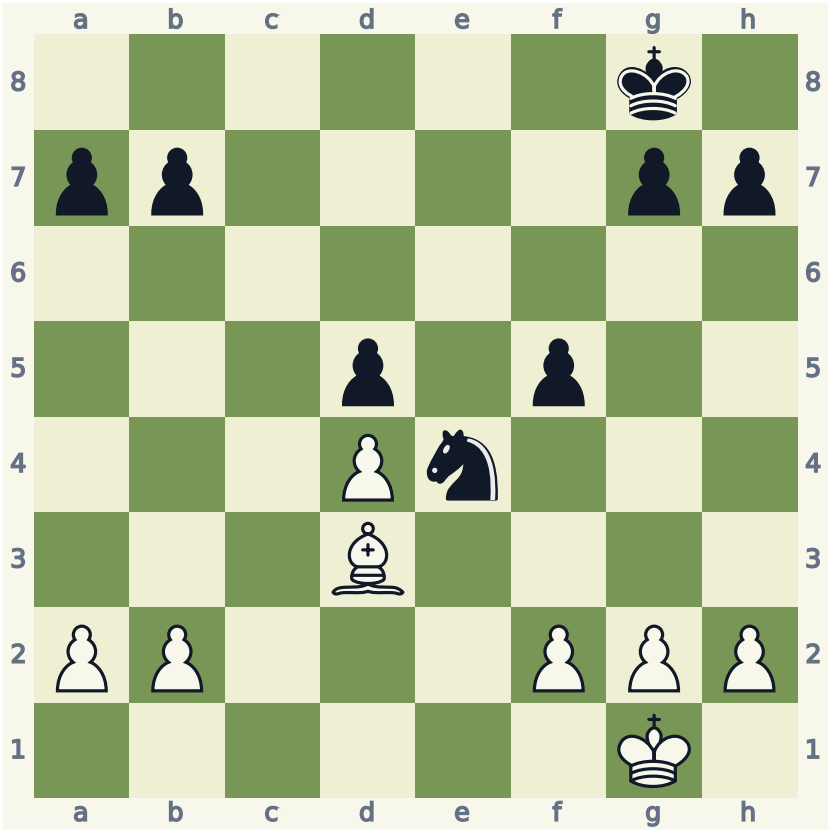
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

The slogan trade when ahead is incomplete. A rook exchange into a drawn pawn ending throws away a win; a queen exchange that destroys your own king shelter can also be wrong.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. What extra recapture does Black have in this version?
- 2. How does ...fxe4 differ from ...dxe4?
- 3. Which ending features must White compare before exchanging?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If Black's king were already on e6, how would the exchange deserve a different evaluation?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 6k1/pp4pp/8/3p1p2/3Pn3/3B4/PP3PPP/6K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Black can recapture with either the d5-pawn or the f5-pawn. A move that changes the identity of the recapturing pawn can change the entire ending.
2. After ...fxe4, the d5-pawn remains and supports e4. White's d4-pawn is blocked by d5, so it is no longer a passed pawn. Black gives up its f-pawn in exchange for a connected central chain.
3. Compare king access, the fixed d4/d5 pawns, the supported e4-pawn and the kingside pawn balance. White must assess whether the bishop is more valuable on the board than the pawn ending obtained by removing the knight. No automatic winning verdict follows from the exchange.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Bxe4 fxe4

Changed feature: Black would enter the pawn ending with a much more active king. That can outweigh the attraction of removing Ne4, so White should calculate central entry squares and pawn races before trading.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

For three exchanges in your games, write the intended benefit and the actual position that resulted. Include one exchange you declined.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 01, 08, 24. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.